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HOW TO SUCK LESS AT JIU JITSU



101 TIPS THAT
ACTUALLY HELP

How to Suck Less at Jiu Jitsu: 101 Tips That Actually Help

by

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Chapter 1: Mindset & Philosophy

1. Embrace the Journey, Not Just the Destination

Let's get the cliché out of the way early: Brazilian Jiu Jitsu is a marathon, not a sprint. In fact, it's a long, often humbling and beautifully gruelling marathon. It's easy to get caught up chasing belts, tapping higher belts, or collecting medals, but obsessing over results can rapidly lead to frustration and burnout, especially in the early stages of the journey when your progress starts to slow (*which it will*).

Real growth in Jiu Jitsu creeps in quietly and gradually. You probably won't even realise your guard is improving until someone who used to pass your guard now struggles. These small, almost invisible gains are the real magic of the process.

Learning to embrace the journey means celebrating these little victories – surviving a little longer in a round you used to lose in the first minute, finally hitting a technique you've been drilling for weeks, or simply just making it to class on a rough day when you didn't feel like training. Shifting your mindset like this builds resilience and actually makes the ride enjoyable.

2. Check Your Ego at the Door

You'll hear this all the time – because it's true. The ego is an invisible opponent that holds us all back from progressing at certain points on our journey. It's the little voice in your ear telling you not to tap to the lower belt you are rolling with. It's the self-doubt that makes you too scared to ask a question in front of the class. It's the part of you that feels like you have to dominate every roll to prove your worth.

But Jiu Jitsu is an art built on exposure and adaptation. You have to put yourself in bad positions to learn how to escape. You need to go through that process of getting smashed when trying new techniques to eventually make them work. You have to be willing to roll with higher belts and lose.

Clinging to your ego will protect your pride, but it inevitably comes at the expense of your progress. By leaving your ego at the door, you create a space where failure is welcomed as part of learning. You can experiment without fear, accept feedback, and keep your mind open when training.

The mats are the ultimate equaliser. They don't care what happened at your last class; they only recognise what you are doing today. Refusing to tap doesn't make you tough; it just gets you injured.

3. Don't Compare Yourself to Others

Everyone's Jiu Jitsu journey is unique to them. Some people are natural athletes. Some people arrive at their first class after years of wrestling or Judo experience. Some people come to jiu jitsu later in life after taking weeks, or even months, to build up the courage to just walk through the door.

As Theodore Roosevelt famously said, "*Comparison is the thief of joy*". It can divert your focus from your own progress and replace it with self-doubt, frustration or even misplaced pride.

If you're the student training twice a week, juggling family life and work commitments, it can be disheartening to compare yourself to a 21-year-old natural athlete who trains twice a day, eats like a pro, and recovers like Wolverine. They are walking a different path, with different resources and circumstances. Their progress doesn't invalidate yours.

On the flip side, if you're the young, naturally athletic beginner dominating early rolls, don't mistake that success for mastery. Outmuscling a hobbyist doesn't mean you're developing real technical depth; it might just mean you're stronger or faster, *for now...*

Comparison is often *very* misleading. You never know what someone else is dealing with, whether they're overcoming fear, injuries, time constraints, or personal battles just to step on the mat. What matters is *your* consistency, *your* effort, and *your* growth.

Your progress isn't about beating others; it's about becoming better than you were yesterday.

4. Get Comfortable Being Uncomfortable

Jiu Jitsu is an art built on pressure, control, and survival. You are going to spend a lot of time stuck in uncomfortable and sometimes claustrophobic positions – under mount, in side control, fighting off subs. These moments test your mindset more than your technique.

The real skill is staying calm in the chaos. Instead of panicking, you will learn to breathe, frame and think. As you improve, you will stop flailing and start problem-solving.

Learning to stay calm when things get rough is one of the most valuable skills you can develop. This mindset shift makes your Jiu Jitsu better and builds real mental toughness. If you can stay cool on the mats, you will be better equipped to handle life off the mats, too.



Get Comfortable Being Uncomfortable

5. Keep Showing Up

There is no magic trick to getting good at Jiu Jitsu. Talent helps. Being athletic helps. But *nothing* beats consistency. Someone who trains three times a week for five years will always eventually outperform the killer who only turns up now and then, no matter how gifted they are.

Life gets busy, and you won't always feel like training, but just showing up, even when you're tired or off your game, is what builds real progress. Consistency creates habits, and habits create skill. Jiu Jitsu is a skill-based sport, and time away leads to regression. So, at a minimum, be on the mat to maintain your progress. Turning up with goals and a purpose will serve you even better.

Not every roll will feel great, and some days you'll feel off. But every time you step on the mat, you are investing in your future self.

6. Help Lower Belts and Learn from Higher Belts

Jiu Jitsu thrives on being a community. Helping lower belts makes you better; it forces you to break down and explain things, and that shows you what you actually know and *what you don't know*.

Training with higher belts is absolute gold. They have already walked your path and can save you time with tips or subtle details that would take you much longer to discover on your own.

Be generous with what you know and stay open to learning from others. The best students are also the best teammates.

7. Patience is a Superpower

Your growth in Jiu Jitsu won't follow a straight line. Some weeks, everything clicks. Others, you'll feel like you've hit a plateau or even like you're getting worse.

This is *completely normal*. Growth happens below the surface, even when it doesn't feel like it. Don't worry if you can't see the improvements; they will be happening if you're putting in the work.

Patience helps you push through the slumps and keep going. If you hang in there long enough, the plateaus will pass, and you will come out the other side stronger.

8. There Are No Absolutes in Jiu Jitsu

One of the first things you learn in Jiu Jitsu is that “*never*” and “*always*” don’t really apply.

Yes, there are principles that hold true most of the time – posture, framing, base, and timing – but the more time you put in on the mats, the more you realise that almost every rule has an exception. What works in one situation might get you submitted in another.

You’ll hear advice like, “Never cross your feet from the back.” And most of the time, that’s great advice. But you also need to understand the risks and when it might be worth taking them. Crossing your feet can expose you to an ankle lock, but it can also give you better control. If you’re smart about it – crossing higher, off to the side, or out of reach – then breaking the rules can actually work in your favour. Sometimes, it’s the right call. Especially when you’re rolling with someone your size or bigger who might catch you in a foot lock before you realise what’s happening, but like most things in Jiu Jitsu, it depends. If you’re controlling a much smaller partner, the risk is lower. And in some cases, crossing your feet *briefly and with control* can actually help stabilise their hips, slow down their escape, or even create the pressure you need to finish the choke. It’s not something to rely on, but it’s not always a mistake either.

This doesn’t mean fundamentals don’t matter. They absolutely do. It just means you can’t treat every piece of advice like it’s written in stone. Context is everything.

Jiu Jitsu isn’t about following a script. It’s about learning how to adapt, solve problems, and trust your own understanding as it grows. Stay curious – and give yourself room to explore the edges.

9. Understand Your Roots

Although on the surface, it might seem that Brazilian Jiu Jitsu is a relatively new art that is only a century old, it actually has a rich history that has been passed through generations in many different forms before it finally reached Brazil. Knowing where

it came from and who paved the way will give you a deeper appreciation and respect for the art. It is also a great reminder to you that you are part of something much bigger.

That respect should include your academy and instructors. Every class you attend is the result of years of sweat, sacrifice, and dedication by your teachers. Arriving on time, being respectful, and showing gratitude to them isn't just being polite. It shows that you value the environment, which is allowing you to grow.

Yes, Jiu Jitsu is a combat sport. But it is also a lifestyle and a philosophy. When you honour its roots, your connection to it, and your own personal development, becomes much stronger.

10. Be a Student for Life

There's no end point in Jiu Jitsu. Even as a black belt with decades of training behind you, there is always more to explore. The game keeps evolving, with new techniques, transitions, and strategies emerging all the time. The ones who keep improving are those who stay curious and humble.

Being a lifelong student means actively seeking out knowledge: attending seminars, watching instructional videos, revisiting fundamentals, asking questions, and trying new stuff in your rolls. It also means knowing that every training partner – *no matter what belt they are* – has something to teach you.

There's always another layer to uncover, another detail to refine, another challenge to face. That's what makes Jiu Jitsu so rewarding. It keeps you curious, keeps you learning, and keeps you coming back – not because it gets easier, but because you keep getting better.

Chapter 2: Approach to Training

11. Start with the Basics

All high-level grapplers have one thing in common: *rock-solid fundamentals*. Before getting into flashy guards, berimbolos or Imanari rolls, make sure you have the core principles locked down. Focus first on base, posture, frames and learning to escape from bad positions. These are the building blocks that lay the foundation for your game.

The fancy moves will crumble in a live roll without solid fundamentals to back them up. Someone with strong fundamentals can shut down high-level attacks just by sticking to the basics.

And don't make the mistake of thinking that fundamentals are just for beginners. It's quite the opposite; they are the highest expression of mastery.



Start with the Basics

12. Drill With Purpose

It can be tempting to just go through the motions and get through the reps to pass time until the rolls at the end of the class. But drilling isn't just about repping moves; it's about staying engaged while you do it and focusing on the finer details of the techniques you have been shown. This is what will make the difference when transitioning a technique from drilling to live rolls.

Pay close attention to the intricacies of each technique: Where is your weight sitting? How do your grips feel? How is your partner reacting?

Ask yourself questions while drilling: Why does this technique work? What happens if I miss a step? What is my opponent likely to do next?

Focused, thoughtful drilling builds skills that actually show up in live rolls. A few mindful reps will beat a hundred sloppy ones every time.

13. Don't Be Afraid to Ask Questions

Asking your instructor or a higher belt for help is one of the best ways to learn, but it's easy to feel intimidated in class, especially when you're new. You might think your question is too basic or that everyone else already understands, and you're the only one not getting it. But here's the thing: asking questions isn't a weakness. *It's actually one of the fastest ways to improve.*

Jiu Jitsu is anything but simple. It's full of layers, details, and movements that often feel counterintuitive. If something isn't clicking for you, it's important to speak up. The chances are, there are others in the class who are wondering the same thing but are too shy to ask. As the saying goes, "*There are no stupid questions – only stupid answers.*" A good instructor won't just tolerate questions; they will welcome them and use them to make things clearer for the whole room.

With that being said, a great habit to develop is to pause and try to troubleshoot the problem yourself first. Could your grip be off? Maybe your angle's wrong? Or did you miss a small but crucial detail in timing? Just giving it a moment of reflection before you ask turns you from a passive student into an active one. And when you do get the answer, it's more likely to stick – because you've already started working through the problem.

Curiosity is a strength. Use it.

14. Train in Themes or Cycles

Jiu Jitsu can feel overwhelming if you try to learn everything at once. It's much better to pick a theme and commit to working on it for a few weeks. For example, if you choose half guard, work on hand positioning and how to frame, learn some sweeps and submissions, look at the position from the other perspective and work some passes, then test it out in sparring.

Many advanced competitors use thematic training. It facilitates deep learning, builds confidence and brings clarity. If you use it regularly, you will rapidly start to see the nuances of a position and understand how techniques connect, noticing details you would miss in scattered learning. And over time, you will develop a much more complete game.

Many academies use this for their method of teaching anyway, so it's easy to follow along with your instructor's theme of the week or month. But if they don't, that's absolutely fine, and just focus on your own training this way.

15. Record What You Learn – But Make It Count

Jiu Jitsu throws a massive amount at you, and honestly, it can feel very overwhelming at times. Every week brings new techniques, added details, new principles, and those little lightbulb moments that come to you mid-roll. It's easy to get home after class, switch off, turn on Netflix and forget most of it by the time the next class rolls around. That's why keeping notes can be such a valuable tool.

There are a vast number of tools available now for note-taking: phone apps, digital journals, voice memos, or even just old-school pen and paper. Recording what you learn helps to solidify new information and track your progress. Some people use bullet points, others draw diagrams or mind maps, and some jot down reflections after sparring. The format doesn't really matter as long as it works for you.

But there's a really important caveat: *those notes only help if you actually review them.*

A lot of people write things down and never look at them again, and when that happens, the value drops off massively. Logging things can still help with memory retention, but the real benefit comes when you go back, especially when you're revisiting a topic or stuck on something that's giving you trouble.

So yes, take notes, but also make time to go back through and reflect on them.

16. Don't Neglect Your Defence

In the early days of training, it's really easy to focus on chasing submissions before learning how to defend them. If you scroll through Instagram or YouTube, you will notice that the number of sexy submissions far outweighs basic defence and escapes.

But defence is what keeps you in the fight, and without any defence, you won't last long. A solid defensive foundation built on posture, timing and escapes will allow you to survive against tougher opponents and, therefore, get more experience out of these rolls. It will also give you the confidence to take more risks and explore new areas of your game without the fear of being punished too harshly for mistakes.

Good defence frustrates opponents, throws them off their game and creates openings. A player with strong escapes who is calm under pressure often controls the tempo of a roll. While offence is flashy, fun and exciting, defence is what gives you staying power and composure.

17. Don't Neglect Your Takedowns

In Jiu Jitsu, it's all too easy to just focus on what happens once the match hits the ground, but every match starts standing, and if you want to be truly well-rounded, you can't afford to ignore your takedowns.

You don't need a deep wrestling background or a full Olympic judo playbook. Just learning a few solid, high-percentage takedowns can dramatically improve your confidence and control in the early moments of a match. Even having one takedown that you drill consistently – something you trust – can make a world of difference. Focus on the fundamentals: establish dominant grips, maintain a stable posture with a strong base, and commit to reliable entries. The more comfortable you are on your feet, the more composed and dangerous you'll be across the board.



Don't Neglect Your Takedowns

18. Don't Neglect Leg Locks

Leg locks are not an optional extra; they are a core part of modern grappling. The leg lock game can seem overwhelming at first, and perhaps a little scary, but avoiding leg locks doesn't keep you safe – *understanding them does*.

If you're new to the leg game, start with structure. Focus initially on understanding limb entanglements and control positions. Then study the mechanics: how joints move, what creates a true breaking point, and how to isolate the limb without exposing yourself.

Just as important as the submissions themselves are the escapes and defences. Knowing how to recognise danger early will help to keep you safe, as will adopting a playful and experimental 'catch and release' approach.

With proper guidance and a technical mindset, leg locks become less of a mystery and more of a powerful tool.

Learn them with respect, not fear.



Don't Neglect Leg Locks

19. Let Your Training Evolve

Your needs in training won't stay the same forever. What matters in your first six months might look completely different a few years in – and that's how it should be.

At first, you're just trying to survive. Then you start building confidence, figuring out what works for you. Later, maybe you're refining the details, or helping others. There are times when you'll want to push hard and test yourself. Other times, you'll pull back, protect an injury, or just focus on showing up when life gets difficult.

There's no single right way to train, but there is a right way *for you*, right now.

Try to check in with yourself every so often. Ask: *What do I need from Jiu Jitsu at this stage?*

20. Don't Be Afraid to Take Breaks – But Always Return

Life happens – you might get injured, family responsibilities might stop you from getting to class, or you might even feel burned out from time to time. But that's okay! Jiu Jitsu should enhance your life, not take over it, and sometimes you just need time off to recover, recharge, and reignite your motivation.

Jiu Jitsu is a marathon, not a sprint, so just make sure you come back! It's absolutely fine to take breaks, but letting them stretch on too long is where people fade out and never return. Even if you come back feeling rusty, the mat will always welcome you back, and you'll find your rhythm in no time.

Chapter 3: Technical Foundations

21. Position Before Submission

There's an old saying in Jiu Jitsu: *position before submission*. And for good reason. One of the most common mistakes early on is rushing to go for a sub before you've truly secured control.

Submissions work best when your opponent has nowhere to go – when their hips are pinned, their posture is broken, and their limbs are isolated. That kind of control doesn't just make your attacks cleaner; *it makes them inevitable*.

Focus on refining your transitions to dominant positions and understanding how to pin someone in place. When your positioning is solid, the submission isn't forced – it just presents itself.

Master the control, and the finish will follow.

22. Be Patient Setting Up Your Subs

This one follows straight on from tip 21. Once you've secured a dominant position, the next step shouldn't be to dive straight in for the tap – it should be to tighten the net.

Submissions shouldn't rely on explosiveness or being snatched with speed and strength. They should, instead, come from patiently applying pressure, removing movement, and eliminating every possible escape. A well-executed submission is the final step in a sequence of control, pressure, and problem-solving.

Think of the submission as the final step in a sequence, not the opening move. It should feel like a slow realisation: your opponent knows what's coming, but they've already lost the ability to stop it.

The best finishes don't happen by force. They happen because you gave your opponent nowhere else to go.

23. Stay Connected – Control Comes Through Contact

Whether you're playing guard or in a dominant position pinning someone, the principle is the same: *connection is control*. Every grip, hook, frame, or wedge is a point of contact that limits your opponent's movement and gives you options. The more contact points you maintain, the more secure your position becomes.

In guard, these contact points are your lifeline. As soon as grips are broken or hooks cleared, your opponent's pass is already in motion. Most guard passes don't happen in a single explosive move; they happen gradually, as you lose contact, one point at a time. Guard retention is about constantly re-establishing those anchors and never allowing complete disconnection.

Similarly, when you're on top, connection creates pressure. A cross face, an underhook, or solid shoulder pressure all add layers of control. Your opponent will have to fight to peel them off. If you let even one go without replacing it, you start to allow them to create space and open the door for escapes, reversals, or even sneaky submissions.

When you stay connected, you stay in control.



Stay Connected – Control Comes Through Contact

24. Don't Just Memorise Moves – Understand Concepts

It's easy to fall into the trap of becoming a technique collector – a few sweeps here, a few subs there, some passes you saw on YouTube last week. But the more you try to memorise every move, the more it starts to feel like chasing a never-ending checklist and the more lost you can become.

Techniques are important, but without understanding *the why behind them*, it's hard to adapt when things don't go exactly as planned. Concepts, such as base, posture, leverage, pressure, framing and kuzushi (we will come back to this shortly), transcend individual moves and are tools that you can use across your entire game.

You don't need a different technique for every situation – you need a solid grasp of the mechanics that shape the situation. Techniques come and go. But concepts?

Concepts evolve with you. They grow as your understanding deepens. And when pressure hits, they are always there.

Train to understand, not just to remember. That's when your Jiu Jitsu really starts to come alive.

25. Make Your Grips Count – Master Kumi Kata

Before the takedown, the sweep, the pass, or the submission – there's the grip. In Judo, it's known as kumi kata, *the art of gripping*. And in Jiu Jitsu, it plays just as vital a role. Grips are your first layer of control over your opponent. They decide who is winning an exchange, who is setting the pace, and who is imposing their game.

In the Gi, that grip might be on a lapel, sleeve, collar or the pants. In No-Gi, it could be a wrist tie, collar tie, underhook or body lock. Regardless of the grip, the principle remains the same: *every grip should be purposeful and made with intention*.

If your grip isn't doing something – breaking posture, stopping movement, or setting up your next step – it's just wasted effort. A strong grip can shut down your opponent before they even get going. A lazy one can put you on the back foot from the first moment.

Grip fighting is one of the most overlooked and undertrained aspects of Jiu Jitsu. Too many people treat it as a throwaway detail – something you do before the “real” roll starts. But it's not just a handshake. It's a battle for control. This can't be emphasised enough; in grappling sports, the person who wins the grip battle will probably win the match.

So don't just grip out of habit. Grip with purpose.

26. Off-Balance Your Opponent – Master Kuzushi

Kuzushi is another great Judo principle that is just as important in Jiu Jitsu. We have all seen those videos of beautifully executed Judo throws that look absolutely effortless. The kind of throw where the uke hits the mat and sits up wearing a look of mild confusion, as if wondering, “What just happened?” The key to that illusion of ease is kuzushi – the art of breaking your opponent’s balance.

The same idea applies in Jiu Jitsu. If your opponent is stable and rooted, you’ll end up muscling through the move, trying to force it to work using strength, speed, or both. But when you take their balance away – with a shift, a pull, or a slight redirection – everything starts to feel lighter and easier.

Kuzushi doesn’t stop at stand-up. It’s everywhere in Jiu Jitsu:

- Off-balancing before a sweep.
- Disrupting posture in closed guard to open the collar.
- Breaking balance during grip fighting to provoke a reaction.

Wherever you want to move your opponent, kuzushi gets you there first. Without it, you’re swimming upstream. With it, everything starts to flow.

27. Always End Up in a Dominant Position

If you’re in the middle of a sweep, a guard pass, or even a submission attempt, ask yourself: *Where am I going to end up?*

If you don’t stabilise your position at the end of a move, you haven’t won anything. A sweep that ends with you off-balance and allows your opponent to go straight back to top position, or a guard pass that leaves space for a hip escape straight back to guard, undoes all the hard work it took to get there.

Make sure you stay on top after a sweep. Make sure you secure your pin after a guard pass before rushing in for a submission or another transition. *Make it a habit to finish techniques in strong, balanced positions.*

The goal isn't just to move – it's to move forward and stay there. This mindset builds a game where you're constantly progressing and never wasting energy or climbing down the ladder of positional hierarchy.

28. Train Both Sides – But Know When It Matters Most

You've probably heard people say that you should develop your game equally on both sides – and while that's a great ideal, it's not always the most practical or efficient approach to training.

When you're attacking – setting up submissions, sweeping, and building traps – you're the one in control. You get to choose how you are setting your grips, building into the technique and timing it. That's why it makes sense to focus on your strong side first, especially when learning something new.

It's not about ignoring balance – it's about building confidence and clarity. Learning a technique well on one side gives you the ability to understand how and why it works. Once that is in place, it becomes much easier to translate it to the other side, rather than trying to split your attention from the start. That way, you're learning with intention and not just chasing symmetry for symmetry's sake.

But escaping? *That's a different story.* You don't get the luxury of deciding which side your opponent passes and sets up side control from, or which arm they attack with an armbar or a Kimura. They do. That's why escapes need to be trained both ways – equally. If you can only implement an escape on one side, you're gambling every time things go wrong.

Guard passing is a slightly interesting side note. Most people pass to their left, so it becomes what we are all most used to defending. So, if you're comfortable passing to your right, you immediately become harder to predict. Having the ability to go both ways doesn't just make you more complete – it makes you more frustrating to deal with.

So no, you don't need to be perfectly ambidextrous. But you do need to know where it matters. Build your offence with focus. Train your escapes with balance. And keep your passing open enough to surprise people.

That's smart Jiu Jitsu.

29. Learn How to Apply Pressure

Pressure is one of the most overlooked and underrated skills in Jiu Jitsu. It's not about size or strength. *It's about how you use your body.*

Good pressure makes you feel heavier than you are. It comes from small things: how you angle your hips, where you place your shoulder, how you keep your weight off the floor and on your opponent. The more of you they have to carry you, the more their frames start to crumble and the less energy you need to spend.

If your top game feels light or easy to escape, don't add speed; add *pressure*. Slow things down. Make them feel every inch of you. That kind of pressure doesn't just wear people down; it breaks their rhythm, especially if they are the sort of player who relies on speed and explosiveness.

If you're unsure how to get that "sticky, heavy" feeling, ask a higher belt to walk you through it. Most of the time, it's not about doing more, it's about doing less more efficiently.

Pressure isn't a brute-force tool. It's a skill. And once you learn it, everything else gets a little bit easier.

30. Practice Chain Drills

Techniques in Jiu Jitsu don't just happen in isolation. You rarely just hit an armbar from guard and that's the end of the story. Multiple actions and reactions will have occurred in a live roll before you reached that destination.

Chain drills link multiple techniques together into a flowing sequence, allowing both partners to move, respond, and transition together. For example:

- Player A attacks with an armbar from guard.
- Player B defends by stacking and passing to side control.
- Player A escapes by reguarding and re-attacks with an armbar, restarting the sequence.

This kind of loop can cycle endlessly, building rhythm, timing, and an understanding of how techniques flow together. After a few rounds, you can switch roles and experience the sequence from the other perspective.

Chain drills help to bridge the gap between static drilling and live sparring. They show you how the game actually flows – not as isolated techniques, but as reactions to reactions. And unlike traditional drilling, both partners stay active and engaged, making the process more dynamic and collaborative.

Chapter 4: Rolling & Sparring

31. Respect Someone's Right to Say No

People train for all sorts of reasons, from all kinds of backgrounds, each with their own personal history. You might be happy to roll with anyone and everyone, but not everyone feels the same.

You're free to decline a roll with anyone, for any reason. You're not obligated to train with anyone. And that goes both ways. You may not know what someone's been through, or why they feel the way they do.

If someone turns down a roll, don't take it personally. Don't press them for a reason. Just move on to the next person. *And know that you're always free to do the same.*

32. Be a Good Training Partner (aka, Don't Be a Dick)

Rolling isn't a fight – it's a mutually beneficial shared experience. You're not just there to get better yourself; you're also helping someone else improve. So, if your partner is smaller, newer, recovering from an injury, or still figuring things out, *please adjust your intensity accordingly!* Don't use raw strength to dominate, and don't treat the round like it's a chance to win some sort of end of class gold medal.

On the flip side, when you're paired with someone more skilled or more physical, rise to the occasion – *but stay respectful*. A good training partner knows when to push and when to ease off. It's not about smashing or surviving – it's about helping each other sharpen each other's games and learn.

And if you're naturally strong or athletic, here's a harsh truth you may not want to hear: using those gifts to bulldoze your way through rolls might work for a while,

especially at white or blue belt. But eventually, that strategy hits a wall. It creates a false sense of progress and puts a low ceiling on your Jiu Jitsu. Technique catches up – and when it does, you'll wish you'd approached your rolls differently and built better habits.

So be generous with your control, thoughtful with your intensity, and honest about your intentions. The better you treat your training partners, the better they'll become – and the more you'll grow with them.



Be a Good Training Partner

33. Don't Be Afraid to “Lose” in Training

Getting swept, passed, or submitted in sparring isn't failure – it's feedback. It shows you where the holes in your game are and gives you a chance to fix them. Avoiding tough positions or dodging partners who challenge you might feel like self-

preservation, but in reality, it's just protecting your ego, and that protection comes at the cost of progress.

The best improvements often come from the rounds where you felt outmatched. So don't worry if you get caught or you feel like you're struggling, but be curious about *why it happened*. What did they do? Where did you overcommit, or hesitate, or lose structure?

When you approach training this way, every so-called "loss" becomes a victory – these losses provide the opportunity for you to isolate problems and search for solutions. You don't need to "win" rounds to level up. You just need to show up honestly, roll with intention, and be willing to get uncomfortable. This way, your understanding will deepen, and you can turn experience into progress.

34. Roll With a Goal in Mind

Instead of jumping into every round on autopilot, take a moment before the roll starts to set a clear intention. *What do you want to work on?* It could be something broad — like developing your butterfly guard — or something more specific, like setting up an omoplata from spider guard. Whatever your focus, having a goal gives your sparring direction. And even if you don't hit it perfectly, it still adds value by keeping your training purposeful.

Having a specific goal in mind helps you avoid falling into old habits or defaulting to the same old patterns. It keeps you engaged and curious, even when things aren't going your way. And if the round goes off-track – *which it often will* – that's okay. Just adjust, stay present, and circle back when you can.

Not every roll needs to be a win. But every roll can move you forward – *if you know what you're aiming for*.



Roll With a Goal in Mind

35. Use Positional Sparring to Sharpen Your Skills

While starting a sparring round standing or from the knees is fun and has its place, not every roll should be free-for-all. It's easy to get stuck doing the same things and relying on your go-to techniques or positions, for example, pulling half guard every round and just playing from there because it's a strong aspect of your game.

Some of the most productive rounds come from positional sparring, particularly starting in positions that you are struggling with. If you're struggling to escape mount, then start every roll there. If you want to improve your closed guard attacks, ask your partner to start inside your guard. This isolates the position you're working on and gives you repeated exposure to problem-solving within a specific context. This kind of focused training accelerates improvement, builds confidence, and helps you systematically patch weaknesses in your game.

36. Roll With All Kinds of Partners

It's easy to settle into a rhythm with a select few training partners who you love training with – the ones who match your pace, your size, your style. And while those rounds can be great, rolling with a wide variety of people really helps your Jiu Jitsu to grow.

Every partner brings something different. White belts force you to slow down and refine your control. Higher belts challenge your timing, expose holes in your game, and teach you to stay calm under pressure. Peers keep you sharp and honest, especially the ones who know your game inside out.

Over time, sparring with the same crew can get stale. You will start to anticipate each other's games, and it gets harder to see where your skills really stand. That's why it's so valuable to roll with people you don't know well – even better if they have a different body type or approach. If you get the chance, visit another gym or hit an open mat too.

The more unfamiliar partners you roll with, the more adaptable and well-rounded your game becomes. Step outside the comfort zone, as that's where things start to get interesting.



Roll With All Kinds of Partners

37. Use Flow Rolling to Develop Timing and Feel

Not every round has to be a battle. Flow rolling – a light, cooperative style of rolling where both partners move fluidly and keep the intensity around 50% - is one of the most underrated tools in Jiu Jitsu.

It's not just "going light." When done well, flow rolling sharpens your timing, improves your transitions, and builds a deeper feel for movement – all without the pressure of trying to win every exchange. You're learning how to stay relaxed, how to move without resistance, and how to shift through different positions with purpose.

Most people, particularly early on in training, can only roll at one speed – all-out. But the best grapplers know how to adjust. They can shift gears depending on the pace, the partner, or the moment. Flow rolling helps you build those gears. It's especially

useful if you're a beginner still figuring things out, or an experienced student wanting to refine movement without wear and tear.

It can actually be more tiring than you expect – but also a lot more fun. If you've never tried it, grab a trusted partner and give it a go. You'll be surprised how much you learn when you're not chasing the tap.

38. Learn to Recognise and Break Your Patterns

It's easy to slip into autopilot during sparring – using the same old passes, reaching for the same grips, reacting with the same defences. And while there's value in having a “go-to” game, it can quietly put limits on your growth if you never step outside it.

Start paying attention to your habits. Do you always shoot for the same takedown? Do you always pass to one side? Do you always go for the exact same submission from side control? These small patterns can add up, and so do the blind spots they create.

Every now and then, try to break your habits. Try out a new pass you've been avoiding. Attack from the other side. Change your grips, change your timing, and see what happens. It might feel awkward at first – that's a sign you're learning. The more willing you are to break your own patterns, the more unpredictable, adaptable, and well-rounded your Jiu Jitsu becomes.

39. Take Time to Reflect – On the Mat or After Class

Rolling is where you test what you know, but real progress comes when you take a moment to process what just happened.

If there's a break between rounds, use that time to pause and reflect. What worked? What didn't? Did you stay composed? Did you stick to your focus, or did you get pulled off course? Even a quick mental recap can help lock in the lesson.

If class is nonstop and you don't have a moment in the middle of training, that's okay. When you get home – or even later that night – take a minute to think it through. Jot down a few quick notes in your journal or phone. A sentence or two is enough to start building self-awareness and direction.

Reflection doesn't need to be formal. Just consistent. It's the bridge between experience and improvement – and the more you build the habit, the faster your game evolves.

40. Watch Yourself Roll – The Camera Sees What You Don't

In the middle of a round, it's easy to miss the details – a late grip, a sloppy transition, a small hesitation that cost you the position. But when you watch your rolls back on video, those moments stand out and you can learn a huge amount from observing them.

Recording yourself is one of the most underused tools in Jiu Jitsu. It doesn't take much – just ask a training partner to grab a quick clip during sparring or set your phone up in the corner. *What you'll see might surprise you:* habits you didn't realise you had, missed opportunities, or even smart decisions you forgot you made.

Over time, watching your rolls helps you get more honest about your game. It's not about judging yourself – it's about noticing patterns, setting better goals, and tracking progress with clarity. You'll start seeing things like: "I always get swept here," or "I pause every time I try to pass on that side."

And if you really want to level up, ask a higher belt or an instructor to watch the videos with you. A second set of eyes can pick up things you might not catch yet.

It's never been easier to record your training, so there's really no reason not to give it a try.

Chapter 5: Competing

41. Competing Isn't for Everyone – But It's Worth Trying

Not everyone is cut out for competition – and honestly, most people who train never step onto the stage. *And that's perfectly fine.* There are so many ways to grow in Jiu Jitsu without ever entering a tournament.

But if you do ever find the courage to try it – *even just once* – the experience can be deeply rewarding.

You'll feel nerves like never before. You'll move differently. You'll make mistakes. And you'll learn more in those five minutes than you might in five weeks of regular class. There's a reason people say, "*One minute of competition reveals more than a week of training.*"

It's not about chasing medals or proving anything. It's about stepping into discomfort, testing yourself, and walking off the mat knowing you did something difficult – just because you could. And whether you ever compete again or not, that moment stays with you.



Competing Isn't for Everyone — But It's Worth Trying

42. Don't Wait for the Perfect Time to Compete

A lot of people think you need to be a higher belt or have everything perfectly sorted before you compete. But the truth is, some of the most significant growth happens when you step into competition early in your journey.

White and blue belts, especially, can benefit in huge ways. Competing gives you immediate feedback: what holds up under pressure, what breaks down, and how your body and mind react when the intensity spikes. You'll get to test your timing, feel the adrenaline, and learn how to breathe when everything in you wants to panic.

And you'll probably never feel “*ready*” anyway! Most people don't. But that's part of the value. Showing up regardless builds confidence you won't get from rolling in class alone. It fast-tracks your development and shows you where to focus next.

You don't have to wait until you feel perfect. Just curious. That's more than enough to take the leap.

43. Recreate the Comp Feel in Training

If you're planning to compete, one of the best ways to prepare is to recreate the feel of a real match in your regular training.

You don't need anything fancy. Just grab a few training partners and run some mock rounds at an open mat: start standing, set a timer, stick to comp rules, and have someone act as a referee and keep score. If a few of you are preparing for the same event, take turns reffing and coaching each other – it's a great way to build sharpness and support at the same time.

Getting used to things like point scoring, resets, pacing, and hearing instructions under pressure will make a big difference. When comp day arrives, you'll be more relaxed – *because it won't feel totally new*. It'll feel like something you've already experienced, just with more eyes watching.

The goal is to make competition feel like just another hard, focused round – not a leap into the unknown.

44. Prepare Like an Athlete, Not Just a Hobbyist

If you're getting ready for competition, don't just train harder – prepare smarter. It's not just training more or getting in extra rolls. It's about preparing with purpose – managing your energy, sharpening your focus, and showing up in the best condition to perform.

That means looking after the things that support your performance: eat well, hydrate properly, get your sleep in check, and start tapering your training as the comp gets closer. The goal is to walk in sharp, not shattered.

Even if it's "*just*" a local comp, treat your prep like you're building toward something bigger. The habits you build now – focus, recovery, and discipline – will carry forward. That mindset shift, from hobbyist to athlete, can make a huge difference on the day of your comp.

You don't need to be perfect. But if you prepare with purpose, you will definitely feel the difference when you step on the mat.

45. Have a Game Plan – and Focus on What You Can Control

Going into a competition without a plan is like turning up to a chess match without knowing how you'll open. You don't need ten steps mapped out, but having a clear, reliable strategy that plays to your strengths is incredibly helpful.

Maybe it's: pull guard, go for a sweep, establish mount, finish with a cross collar choke. Something simple, direct, and familiar. It gives you something to settle into – a way to anchor your nerves and focus your energy when the adrenaline kicks in.

Of course, competitions rarely go perfectly. At least one person's plan will get disrupted. That's where having a backup matters. What if you get taken down? What if your sweep doesn't land? A well-prepared competitor knows their plan A, but has also trained for plan B – and maybe plan C too. You don't need to cover every possibility, but it helps to run through the most likely scenarios in training. That way, you're less likely to freeze on the day.

Competition nerves can lead to panic. "*What if this? What if that?*" There are some things you can control, and some things you can't. Being well conditioned, having a game plan, knowing the rules, having the right gi – in short, being prepared – is in your control.

Yes, your opponent may be better than you. That's completely outside your control, so try not to worry about it.

You're going to feel nervous leading up to the competition, and it will likely get worse as the event gets closer. You go to bed the night before nervous, and the realisation when you wake up on game day is even worse. You watch the schedule, your match gets closer, you feel the butterflies – and then suddenly, you're up.

It's all normal. And the match is going to happen, regardless of how nervous you feel, so just accept it.

One of you will have better Jiu Jitsu or a better strategy. That person will win. Worrying about it will not change a damn thing.

46. Make Sure You Understand the Rules – But Don't Rely On Them

Before you compete, make sure you take the time to properly understand the rules – how points are scored, what constitutes an advantage, what submissions are legal, how long the match lasts, etc. It matters more than many people think.

But don't build your whole game around trying to game the system. Points, strategies, and rule awareness are helpful – but they're not a substitute for solid Jiu Jitsu. The fundamentals still win matches: strong positional control, efficient movement, solid guard retention and passing, and clear submission setups.

By all means, use the rules to your advantage – slow things down strategically if you're ahead, push the pace when you're down – but don't let your entire approach revolve around trying to exploit technicalities. That kind of game will always have limits.

Understand the rules. Use them wisely. But let your Jiu Jitsu do the heavy lifting.

47. Control Your Nerves by Controlling Your Breathing

Everyone experiences some degree of nerves before a match – even black belts. It's a completely normal, physiological response to the intensity of competition. That rush of adrenaline, the racing heartbeat, the dry mouth... it's all part of your body's built-in '*fight or flight*' response. It's how your system prepares you for a perceived threat – even if that threat is just stepping onto the mat in front of a crowd. If you don't manage it, that sensation can feel overwhelming and can cloud your thinking and drain your energy before the match even starts.

One of the most powerful ways to settle your system is through your breathing. One tried and tested method is *Box Breathing* – a technique used by Navy SEALs to stay calm under pressure. You breathe in for 4 seconds, hold for 4, exhale for 4, hold again for 4 – and repeat. It's simple, discreet, and highly effective for regaining control.

Another helpful technique is 4-6 breathing, which is recommended by many psychologists for managing anxiety. This one is done by inhaling gently for 4 seconds, then exhaling slowly for 6. That longer exhale helps activate your parasympathetic nervous system – the part of your body responsible for calm, recovery, and restoring balance after stress.

It's helpful to practise both techniques before a competition, especially during training between rounds. This way you can choose your favourite, and it will become second nature. (There are plenty of simple walkthroughs and demos on YouTube that are easy to follow.)

You can then use your breathing before you step onto the mat to steady your mind and body. And if things start to spiral – your heart's racing or your thoughts are all over the place – don't ignore it. Breathe through it. Oxygen isn't just for your muscles – it keeps your mind clear, your reactions sharp, and your body in control.

You can't always control your nerves – but you can control your breath. And that might make all the difference to you on the day of your competition.



Control Your Nerves by Controlling Your Breathing

48. Pace Yourself and Manage Your Energy

One of the easiest ways to lose a match is to burn yourself out too soon. It's tempting to come out flying, grip hard, move fast, and try to overwhelm your opponent. But going full speed from the start, especially without control, often leads to quick fatigue, blown grips, and easy opening for your opponent.

A smarter approach is learning to manage your energy. That means knowing when to push and when to pause. Take the opportunities to slow things down – to settle your breathing, reset your grips, and make your opponent carry more of the effort.

If your opponent is fading, then yes, by all means turn it up, but if they're wild and frantic, try to keep the pace slow, controlled, and tiring. Let them burn themselves out trying to force the fight.

Controlling the match isn't just about position. *It's also about tempo.* The more gears you have, and the more you know when to shift, the harder you will be to deal with.

49. Celebrate Courage, Not Just Victory

Stepping onto the mat in front of a crowd, your friends, and your teammates – and knowing you might fail when all eyes are on you – *takes real courage.* It doesn't matter if it's your very first comp or your tenth; putting yourself out there really isn't easy. That act alone is something of real value that you should be proud of.

It doesn't matter if you win or lose. You faced pressure. You took a risk. You tested your Jiu Jitsu – and yourself – in a way most people never will. That experience shapes you far more than any medal ever could.

So, by all means, celebrate the result if things go well. But more than that, honour the courage it took just to show up. And whether you win or lose, do both graciously.

50. Don't Get Stuck Chasing Medals

Medals are great. Podium photos feel good. But don't let them become the only the reason you compete. They're milestones – not meaning.

You compete to test yourself. To sharpen your skills. To step into discomfort and see what you're made of. Winning is satisfying, yes – but it doesn't always teach you much. Losing, as painful as it can be, often tells you far more about your Jiu Jitsu, your preparation, and your resilience.

So don't get too wrapped up in outcomes. They come and go. What matters more is how you performed, what you learned, and how you responded when things didn't go your way.

Chapter 6: Injury Prevention & Recovery

51. Tap Early, Tap Often

This one is *REALLY* important. Tapping is not a sign of weakness. It is not “losing.” Tapping is how we communicate with each other when we are rolling. It’s how we stay safe and how we learn.

For beginners, understanding when to tap is one of the most important things to learn. It is integral to your growth as a student, and if you don’t learn how to do it quickly, your jiu jitsu journey will be a short one.

Refusing to tap in the name of pride can lead to serious injuries – torn knees, jacked-up elbows, and weeks or even months off the mat. If you’re in discomfort or close to being submitted, the smart move is to tap, ask what you did wrong, and then go again.

With time and experience, you’ll learn when to push limits more safely. But until then, and even after, it’s crucial to remember that tapping early keeps you on the mat and in the game. It’s not about winning every round – it’s about staying in the game long-term.



Tap Early, Tap Often

52. Listen to Your Body – It’s Trying to Tell You Something

Some injuries are just bad luck – a sudden twist, an awkward landing, a movement that goes the wrong way at the wrong time. But many others build up slowly. They give you warnings: a tight shoulder, an aching knee, a tweak in your back that’s bothering you.

This is your body trying to tell you something: *“Something’s not quite right – ease up.”*

You don’t have to stop training every time something feels off, but you do need to pay attention. Modify your sessions. Avoid the movements that aggravate it. Give your body the time and space it needs to recover.

And if something doesn’t feel right for more than a few days – or the pain keeps coming back – don’t just guess. Get it checked. Go and see a physio, a doctor, or

another healthcare professional so that you can get a diagnosis early, before a small, easily treatable problem becomes a long-term issue.

Training through warning signs isn't a sign of toughness – *it's short-sighted.*

Listening to your body isn't a sign of weakness, it's what keeps you on the mats for the long run – not stuck injured on the sidelines.



Listen to Your Body – It's Trying to Tell You Something

53. Don't Skip the Warm-Up

It's not the most exciting part of training, but it's definitely one of the most important. Cold muscles, tight joints, and rushed starts are a fast track to injury, especially in a sport that is as physical and unpredictable as Jiu Jitsu.

Warming up properly isn't just about doing a few jumping jacks or going through the motions. It's about preparing your body to move with control and intent. That

means elevating your heart rate, activating your muscles, and moving your joints through a full range of motion.

Many old-school warm-ups focused on static stretching, but this should be avoided, especially if you're not already warm. Studies have shown that static stretching on cold muscles can actually reduce performance and increase injury risk. Instead, focus on *dynamic mobility work*: leg swings, shoulder rolls, hip circles, controlled neck movement, followed by light positional drilling or technical work before starting to do any sparring.

Here's the truth: only you know if your body's ready. If the class warm-up doesn't quite get you there – especially on cold mornings or in winter – show up a few minutes early and take care of it yourself. It's not extra. It's essential.

A good warm-up doesn't just help you perform better. It helps you stay on the mats longer.



Don't Skip the Warm-Up

54. Recovery Is the Foundation of Consistency

Rest is often highly undervalued by Jiu Jitsu players, but it's incredibly important. Resting is sometimes seen as a weakness, but it's not. It should be built into your

weekly training program. If you treat it like a skill, it becomes one of your biggest assets.

Training hard without recovery is a shortcut to burnout. Overreaching can quickly turn into overtraining, and your body starts to break down. Your energy levels and performance will start to decline, and your risk of injury can rise sharply. You may feel constantly run down – physically drained, mentally flat, and more irritable than usual. Strength fades, motivation dips, and training begins to feel like a grind. Minor aches become persistent issues, sleep quality drops, and instead of progressing, you either plateau... or start to slide backwards.

Make sure you schedule rest days and protect them. Get plenty of sleep, eat properly, and do things that reset you, both mentally and physically. That could be walking, reading, or just not thinking about Jiu Jitsu for a day. How you do it isn't important, just make sure you give yourself real space to recover.

55. Balance Full Rest with Active Recovery

Once you've committed to making recovery part of your routine, the next step is learning how to use it well. Rest isn't all or nothing – it exists on a spectrum. Some days, you'll need to step away completely. Others, you can stay connected without adding more stress to your system. That's where *active recovery* comes in.

Active recovery is low-intensity movement that supports healing. It promotes blood flow, improves mobility, and helps your body unwind, but without stressing your nervous system or irritating sore joints. For Jiu Jitsu players, that could include light solo drills, flow rolling at reduced intensity, or some form of mobility work or stretching. You're still engaged – just not overloaded.

On days when fatigue runs deeper or injuries need time, full rest is the right call. Sleep in. Walk. Read. Take a mental and physical break from the grind. You're not stepping back – you're laying the foundation for consistency.

Knowing when to rest and which type of rest you need is just as important to your training in the long term as learning new sweeps and submissions.

56. Build Strength Off the Mats to Stay Strong On Them

If you want to be able to handle tougher rounds with less strain, stay injury-free, and keep showing up long-term, some form of strength training off the mats is one of the best investments you can make.

You don't need to train like a powerlifter or spend hours in the gym – two 30-minute full-body resistance sessions a week are enough to make a massive difference. Focus on compound movements like squats, deadlifts, rows, and presses. Add in some core work and prioritise good form over heavy loads.

Think of it as *body armour*: stronger muscles protect your joints, help absorb force during scrambles and reduce the chances of common injuries like pulled hamstrings, shoulder issues, and tendon irritation at the elbows and wrists.



Build Strength Off the Mats to Stay Strong On Them

57. Mobility Work Matters

Jiu Jitsu asks a lot of your body and puts it in positions it was never designed to be in. Your spine gets compressed when you're stack passed. Your shoulders are cranked into deep internal rotation from kimura traps. Your hip flexors stay shortened and overloaded from hours of playing open guard. And your ankles and knees take constant stress from limb entanglements and awkward scrambles.

If you don't have the mobility to handle that, you'll end up forcing things, muscling through bad mechanics, and putting yourself at risk. That's where *mobility work* comes in.

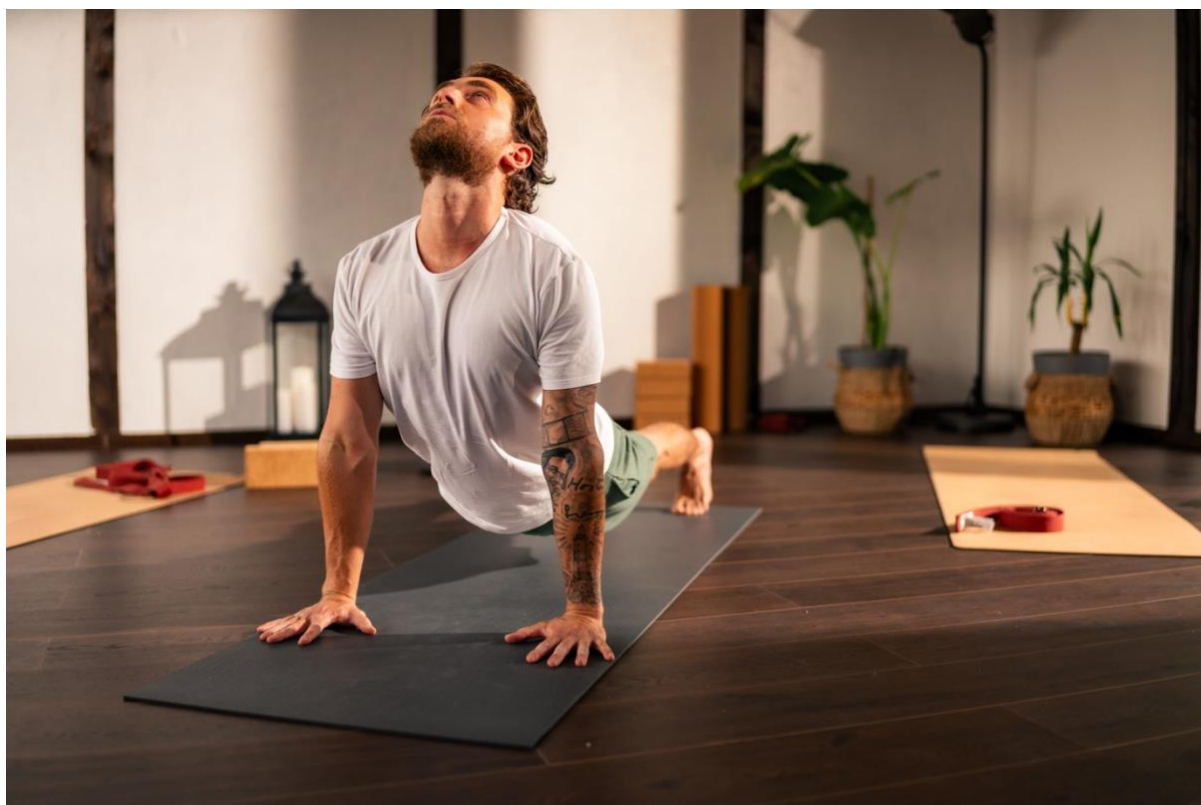
And no, mobility isn't just stretching. It's about increasing your active, controlled range of motion – the ability to move well, with strength and stability, through the positions Jiu Jitsu throws at you.

What does mobility for BJJ look like?

- *Hip mobility drills* – like 90/90s, lizard crawls, deep squat holds
- *Shoulder stability work* – scapular CARs (Controlled Articular Rotations), banded activations, down-dog pulses
- *Thoracic spine control* – cat-cow, thread-the-needle, segmental rotations
- *End-range training* – using systems like FRC (Functional Range Conditioning)
- *Full range of motion strength work* – training lifts and movements through their complete range to build usable flexibility

And yes, yoga absolutely counts – especially dynamic styles like vinyasa or power yoga that focus on strength, control, and breath. These build body awareness, joint control, and fluid movement – all of which translate beautifully to the mat. Just skip overly passive approaches (like yin yoga) if your goal is performance – those are great for recovery, but not for functional control.

The best part? You really don't need to spend hours on it. Even 10 focused minutes a day can change how you move, how you recover, and how you feel after training.



Mobility Work Matters

58. Communicate With Your Training Partners

If you're dealing with an injury – *even a small one* – let your training partner know before the round starts. A lot of avoidable injuries happen because someone didn't realise you were carrying a tweak and pushed through a position you couldn't defend.

Most training partners will gladly adjust if they know what's going on. And if they don't? You're well within your rights to sit that round out or roll with someone else. That's not being dramatic – it's simply looking after your long-term health.

Clear communication isn't awkward. It's responsible. The more we look out for each other, the safer and more sustainable training becomes for everyone.

59. Rehab Properly – Don't Let Impatience Set You Back

Coming back from injury is hard. You miss the mats, the rhythm, your teammates – and as soon as you start feeling almost okay, the temptation to jump back in is real.

But rushing your return too soon often leads to setbacks – and they're often worse than the original injury. What could've been a few weeks off turns into months on the sidelines.

Follow your rehab plan. Don't skip steps. Start with light drills, rebuild confidence with controlled movement, then ease into live rolling when you're truly ready. And if something doesn't feel right – *stop*.

Respect your body's timeline, not your impatience. A smart return now saves you from a much longer break later.

60. Play the Long Game – Your Goal Is to Train for Life

Injuries might slow you down, but they don't have to end your journey. The real goal in Jiu Jitsu isn't just winning rounds or collecting medals – it's being able to train for the next 10, 20, even 30 years.

That kind of longevity doesn't happen by accident. It comes from the small choices you make every day: how you warm up, how you roll, how you rest and recover – *the stuff we've already talked about*. It means knowing when to push and when to pull back.

Don't sacrifice long-term health for short-term ego. The most respected grapplers aren't always the strongest or the flashiest. They're the ones who stayed consistent, stayed healthy, and stayed on the mat.

Train smart now, so you can keep training later.

Chapter 7: Lifestyle & Nutrition

61. Your Jiu Jitsu Will Reflect Your Lifestyle

There's no avoiding this one – how you live your life off the mat will eventually show up on it. Poor diet, high stress, and long hours sitting will drain your energy, dull your performance, and slow your recovery. But when you sleep well, move regularly, eat good food (most of the time), and manage your stress, it lifts everything you do on the mats.

You don't need to live like a monk. But you *do* need to pay attention to the habits that either support or sabotage your training, and adjust them accordingly. Small changes – going to bed earlier, walking more, eating cleaner, breathing deeper – add up over time.

You've probably seen the #jiujitsulifestyle all over social media: the beach rolls, the acai bowls, the post-training photos at golden hour. And sure, there's nothing wrong with enjoying the aesthetic. But the real Jiu Jitsu lifestyle? It's finishing your mobility work when the couch looks more inviting. It's taking five minutes to stretch after a long, tiring day. It's showing up when progress feels slow, and it's prioritising recovery over instant gratification.

62. Stay Hydrated – And Don't Forget Your Electrolytes

Even mild dehydration – as little as 1–2% of your body weight lost through sweat – can have a highly negative effect on your performance. When you are dehydrated, endurance falls off, reaction time slows, strength fades, and your mind starts to feel foggy or flat.

Most Jiu Jitsu sessions are fairly long – 1-2 hours – and relatively high-intensity compared with many other sports and martial arts, and as a consequence, it's easy to lose fluids fast. And you're not just sweating out water, you're also losing vital electrolytes such as sodium (the primary electrolyte lost in sweat and most important electrolyte to replace), potassium, and magnesium, that your body needs to function properly. If you're cramping, feeling unusually tired mid-roll, or struggling to recover between rounds, it might not be your cardio – it might just be dehydration catching up with you.

The fix is simple – but it's not just about chugging water after class. Start hydrating before training, sip water between rounds, and replenish after with both fluids and electrolytes. That might mean using a proper sports drink or a quality electrolyte supplement that includes the key minerals like sodium. These help your body absorb and retain the fluids more effectively, supporting performance and recovery.

Also, don't wait until you're thirsty – this is a late sign of dehydration, particularly in the context of athletic performance. By the time you're thirsty, you're already way behind. Drink consistently throughout the day, not just around training.



Stay Hydrated – And Don't Forget Your Electrolytes

63. Fuel Your Training with Real Food

You are what you eat – and your body runs on what you put into it. If you're regularly training, you need real fuel: food that supports energy, recovery, and long-term health.

Junk food, sugar-heavy snacks, and oversized meals right before class might be convenient and satisfy cravings, but they'll leave you feeling slow and sluggish when you hit the mats.

It's much better to focus on whole foods – lean protein, complex carbs, healthy fats, and plenty of fruit and veg. These give your body what it actually needs to train hard and bounce back. A good rule of thumb is to eat a balanced meal 2–3 hours before training. Then, after class, refuel with a mix of protein and carbs to kickstart your recovery.

Your diet doesn't need to be perfect, but it should be consistent and eating mindfully will support the way you want to move, feel, and live.



Fuel Your Training with Real Food

64. Don't Train on Empty – Even a Snack Helps

In a perfect world, you'd get a balanced meal 2–3 hours before training (*see the last tip*). But let's be honest – life doesn't always work that way.

If you're heading to class under-fuelled, especially after a long day or on an empty stomach, your energy, focus, and coordination will take a hit. And that can increase your risk of injury, too.

Even something small – a banana, a few nuts, or a protein shake – can give your body enough to get through the session strong. You don't need a feast. Figure out what sits well in your stomach and keep it simple. Just don't go in on empty.

65. Sleep Is a Superpower

Forget fancy supplements or recovery hacks – *nothing beats sleep*. This is when your body repairs muscles, balances key hormones, and, crucially, locks in the Jiu Jitsu you trained that day. If you're not sleeping well, you're literally leaving progress on the table.

You should be aiming for 7–9 hours of quality sleep a night. Build a simple wind-down routine. Reduce screen time before bed. Keep your room cool, quiet, and dark. These small changes make a much bigger difference than many people realise.

Sleep scientist Matthew Walker suggests that our modern habits of late nights and excessive caffeine consumption may one day be viewed similarly to how we now regard past practices like indoor smoking – once seen as normal, later recognised as harmful to our health.

Better sleep = better rolls, better focus, faster recovery, and fewer injuries.



Sleep Is a Superpower

66. Caffeine: Your Legal Performance Enhancer

Jiu Jitsu isn't just physical – it's also highly cognitive. You need to make decisions fast, stay alert under pressure, and respond with precision. That's where caffeine can help – not just as a physical booster, but as a mental one, too.

Used in moderation, caffeine (*especially in the form of coffee*) has been shown to improve strength, endurance, and even reaction time. In fact, it's one of the most widely studied – and competition-legal – performance enhancers available. Some research even shows strength and force improvements in Jiu Jitsu athletes specifically after taking caffeine before training.

You don't need much – just a moderate dose (e.g. one or two cups of coffee) before training can boost focus, improve decision-making, and help you stay mentally engaged – even if you didn't sleep well the night before. And if you're looking for a mild cognitive boost without a full cup of coffee, a few squares of dark

chocolate (which contains caffeine and other mild stimulants like theobromine) can be a tasty option that gives you a nice little lift without going overboard.

That being said, caffeine is a double-edged sword. Too much can leave you jittery, anxious, with an upset stomach, or wide awake at 2 a.m. It's also easy to build a tolerance. *Don't ignore the warnings in the previous tip.* Like anything else in training (*and in life!*) – use it with respect and in moderation, and listen to your body.

Used wisely, caffeine can help you roll sharper, think faster, and get more out of your sessions. Just don't let it become a crutch, and if you have any underlying health conditions or concerns about caffeine use, it's best to consult a healthcare professional before adding it to your routine.



Caffeine: Your Legal Performance Enhancer

67. Cut Weight Smart – or Maybe Don't Cut at All

If you're thinking about cutting weight for a competition, do it carefully – and ask yourself if it's really necessary. Crash diets, extreme dehydration, and last-minute weight drops might help you make the number on the scale, but they can wreck the things you actually need on the mat: strength, endurance, and mental sharpness.

Unless you're competing at a high level where cutting weight might provide you with a small advantage, you will usually be better off competing at your natural weight. You'll feel better, move better, and enjoy the experience a lot more.

Instead of chasing an arbitrary weight class, focus on clean eating, consistent training, and showing up well-rested and sharp. The goal isn't just to make weight – it's to perform well and stay healthy. If you think you'll lose because your opponent is a couple of kilograms heavier, you need better Jiu Jitsu.

It isn't worth compromising your immune system, increasing your risk of injury, or causing long-term health problems.

68. Jiu Jitsu Can Feel Like Therapy – But It's Not a Cure-All

Jiu Jitsu won't fix everything, but it can definitely improve things and help you cope better with life's problems.

For a lot of people, training becomes *more than just exercise*. It becomes a space to breathe again. When life feels heavy – when you're stressed, anxious, burned out, or just overwhelmed – the mats offer something simple and rare: *full presence*. You can't get lost in your thoughts when someone's trying to choke you or pass your guard. For that hour, you're here – and nowhere else.

There's something healing in the rhythm of it all. The movement. The structure. The quiet repetition. You learn to breathe through pressure. To stay calm when things aren't going your way. To work through failure and keep showing up. It doesn't magically solve your problems – but it often clears just enough mental fog to help you face them.

There's real science behind it, too. Grappling-based martial arts like Jiu Jitsu have been shown to help reduce anxiety, improve mood, and build emotional resilience. For many of us, it's the closest thing to meditation that actually works – not sitting still, but moving with purpose.

But here's the disclaimer: Jiu Jitsu can support mental health, but it's not a substitute for professional help. If you're struggling – *really struggling* – talk to someone. Therapy, medication, community, rest – they all have their place. And they don't cancel out what the mats give you. They can work side by side.

Jiu Jitsu won't make everything better. But it might help you feel more present, more resilient, and more at peace. And that, for many of us, is more than enough.



Jiu Jitsu Can Feel Like Therapy – But It's Not a Cure-All

69. Balance Your Training With the Rest of Your Life

It's easy to get swept up when you first fall for Jiu Jitsu. Suddenly, you're training five or six days a week, skipping social stuff, watching instructionals at 1 a.m., and thinking about guard passes during work calls. We've all been there.

And for some people, that kind of focus works – it gives structure, purpose, even a sense of identity that might've been missing before. But over time, it's worth asking yourself: *Can I keep this up? Is this helping me grow, or starting to wear me down?*

Balance doesn't have to mean equal time across everything, or a packed calendar of hobbies. It just means taking care of the parts of your life – and your health – that keep you steady. That might be time with family. It might be rest. It might be having something outside the gym that reminds you who you are when you're not wearing a gi.

Ironically, the more balanced you are off the mat, the better you tend to be on it. You show up fresher, think more clearly, and actually enjoy the process more. You're not burning out – you're building something that is sustainable instead.

Let Jiu Jitsu be a meaningful part of your life – not your entire identity.

70. Consistency Beats Intensity

You don't need to train like a machine or crush every session, but you do need to *keep showing up*.

Consistency isn't about grinding harder – it's about making it easier to train, even when life gets busy. Pack your bag the night before. Plan your sessions around your work week. Cook a few meals in advance so you're not grabbing junk on the way to class. These little routines add up and make showing up easier.

Over time, they shift your identity. You become the person who trains regularly, eats better, and sleeps deeper – not because you're constantly motivated, but because it's just part of your life now.

There's a reason people say, "*A black belt is just a white belt who didn't quit.*" It's not about being perfect. It's about finding a system that keeps you coming back – even on the days you don't feel like it.

That's how people become black belts. Not through heroic effort – but through habits that support them, one day at a time.

Chapter 8: Gi & No-Gi Specific Advice

71. Gi and No-Gi Are the Same – and Totally Different

To the untrained eye, Gi and No-Gi can look like two totally different sports. One's slower, full of grips and lapel battles. The other's faster, slipperier, and more scramble-heavy. But underneath the surface, the foundations are exactly the same: leverage, timing, pressure, and connection.

The difference lies in *how those principles are applied*.

In the Gi, you've got grips and fabric to slow things down. You can control posture, tie up limbs with lapels, and build layered control that forces your opponent to play your game.

In No-Gi, it's a different feel. With no cloth to hang on to, you rely more on underhooks, body locks, head position, and constant pressure. It's faster, looser, and often less forgiving – but it teaches you to move fluidly and stay connected.

Think of Gi and No-Gi like two dialects of the same language. The mechanics are the same – but the rhythm, timing, and phrasing all shift. Once you understand that, you'll start to pick things up faster, adapt more easily, and train smarter across both styles.



Gi and No-Gi Are the Same – and Totally Different

72. Don't Be a One-Style Wonder

Once you understand the differences between Gi and No-Gi, the real growth comes from training both. You don't have to choose one over the other – and honestly, you shouldn't. In fact, each style brings something unique to your game.

The Gi sharpens your defence, teaches patience, and helps you deal with complex grip threats. No-Gi dials up your movement, pace, and ability to stay calm in the chaos.

Training both Gi and No-Gi makes your Jiu Jitsu sharper, more adaptable, and way harder to figure out. Each style pushes your game in different directions — and the skills you build in one often show up in the other, in ways you don't always see coming.

It also keeps things interesting. Switching formats forces you to adjust your timing, solve new problems, and think differently. It breaks habits, refreshes your creativity, and keeps you evolving.

They're not rivals – they're two sides of the same art. The more time you spend in both, the more complete your game becomes.

73. Check the Rules – They're Not Always the Same

Not all tournaments run on the same rules – and Gi and No-Gi competitions often have very different ones. What's legal in one might get you disqualified in the other.

Leg locks are usually the biggest grey area. In Gi, submissions like toe holds, kneebars, and especially heel hooks are usually reserved for brown belt and above – sometimes not even allowed then. But in No-Gi, the same techniques might be legal at blue or even white belt, depending on the event.

Other rules also shift: reaping is treated differently across organisations, and grip-based offences (like grabbing inside sleeves or pant legs) are obviously unique to Gi. Uniform checks really matter in the Gi – not so much No-Gi.

The point is: don't assume. Gi and No-Gi have different rules – and those rules can change between organisations. A move that wins you a match under one ruleset might get you disqualified under another.

So, if you're competing, *study the rule set carefully*. Know what's allowed at your level, in your division, under that specific promotion. It only takes a few minutes – and it could save you your match.

74. Use Gi Training to Sharpen Your Defence

Training in the Gi forces you to deal with more control points, more grips, and more submission threats. Every sleeve, collar, lapel, and pant leg becomes a handle your opponent can use against you. As a result, you're constantly defending layered attacks and grip chains that don't exist in No-Gi.

This environment naturally sharpens your defence. You learn to stay calm under pressure, manage multiple threats, and develop more precise timing in your escapes. You can't just explode or slip out – you have to escape properly, with structure and crisp technique.

And here's the bonus: if your defence is strong in the Gi, it often translates extremely well to No-Gi. Without the grips and friction of the Gi, many No-Gi escapes become easier – but the habits and positional awareness you've built remain the same.

Think of Gi training as resistance training for your defensive game. If you can survive the Gi, you'll thrive without it.



Use Gi Training to Sharpen Your Defence

75. Use No-Gi to Sharpen Your Submission Game

In No-Gi, there are fewer grips, fewer control points, and fewer submission options. That might sound limiting – but it actually forces you to become a more precise, aggressive, and opportunistic attacker.

Without lapels or sleeves to slow things down, No-Gi submissions rely on speed, timing, and fluid transitions. You have to move quickly, isolate limbs on the fly, and commit to attacks with confidence. It's a faster game – and it rewards clean technique and sharp instincts.

This pressure-cooker environment is the perfect training ground for developing a high-percentage submission style. *And here's the payoff:* when you take that mindset back into the Gi, your submission game becomes even more dangerous. Now you've got grips, friction, and control on your side – and you already know how to finish without them.

If your submissions work in No-Gi, *they'll work even better in the Gi.*

76. Use Gi Training to Build Technical Precision

Gi grappling naturally slows the game down. With so many grips, friction, and control points, the pace becomes more methodical – and that's a good thing. It forces you to focus on the details: your angles, timing, posture, and weight distribution.

In the Gi, explosive movement alone won't get you far. Trying to rely purely on athleticism usually results in getting tied up, swept, or submitted by high-level players. This levels the playing field, especially against bigger or stronger opponents, and pushes you to refine your technique over brute strength.

Training in the Gi helps you see the micro-adjustments that make techniques work – the kind of details that often get blurred in No-Gi scrambles. You'll learn to move with more control, connect positions more cleanly, and roll with more intention. The Gi is an excellent tool for sharpening your fundamentals to develop crisp and efficient technique.

77. Use Gi Training to Build Patience and Strategy

With more friction and more grip options, you can't simply scramble out of bad positions or explode your way through transitions. Every movement matters. Every grip creates a new threat or opportunity. You're forced to think, plan, and problem-solve your way through the roll.

That's why Gi Jiu Jitsu is often called "human chess". It teaches you to look beyond the immediate exchange – to anticipate, to bait, and ultimately trap your opponent. You stop chasing quick wins and start setting your attacks up several moves in advance.

Training in the Gi develops strategic awareness and patience. You learn when to hold, when to advance, and how to build pressure methodically instead of rushing into mistakes. It's one of the best environments to sharpen your timing, tighten your technique, and develop a tactical mind.

78. Use No-Gi to Build Positional Control

Controlling someone in No-Gi is a different kind of challenge. Without lapels, sleeves, pants, or belts to hold onto, maintaining a dominant position requires precision, pressure, and body awareness.

In No-Gi, you have to rely on underhooks, overhooks, tight frames, and good weight distribution to stay connected. Every inch matters. You can't stall or rest in position – your opponent is constantly slipping, turning, or scrambling to escape. This forces you to learn how to control with your body, and not just your hands.

And when you bring those skills back to the Gi? Your control becomes next level. Now, in addition to your positional tools, you also have friction and grips to back you up. If you can pin someone No-Gi, you'll feel like you have superpowers in the Gi.

79. No-Gi Prepares You for the Unexpected

If you're training Jiu Jitsu for self-defence – even just in the back of your mind – it's worth remembering that real-world situations often don't come with grips.

Most attackers won't be wearing a gi. You won't have lapels, sleeves, or pant legs to rely on. No-Gi teaches you how to control the body directly – using positioning, pressure, and connection rather than grabbing fabric.

And if they *do* happen to be wearing a jacket? Even better – you've trained for that too.

No-Gi helps make your Jiu Jitsu more adaptable. And when things don't go to plan, that's exactly what you need.

80. Build Two Games – But Let Them Overlap

You don't need to reinvent your Jiu Jitsu for Gi and No-Gi – *but you do need to adapt.*

The best approach is to develop two slightly different games that share the same principles, but use tools suited to the format. In the Gi, you might use spider guard, collar grips, and cross-collar chokes. In No-Gi, this might shift into butterfly guard, wrist control, and front headlock attacks.

The key is to focus on positions that exist in both styles – like half guard, mount, back control, and side control – then tailor your grips, guard game, submissions, and transitions accordingly. This keeps your overall game cohesive while allowing you to be effective in either format.

Build two games. Same base, different tools. That way, you stay adaptable without having to start from scratch every time you switch the ruleset.



Build Two Games – But Let Them Overlap

Chapter 9: Dealing With Plateaus

81. Accept That Plateaus Are Part of the Process

No matter how long you've been training, you'll hit points where progress feels invisible. You're showing up, working hard, but nothing seems to click. Sometimes it even feels like you're getting worse.

It's frustrating — but it's *completely normal*.

Plateaus aren't failure; they are part of how learning works. Your brain and body are processing, adjusting, and recalibrating — even if it doesn't feel like it when you're stuck in the middle of one.

A nice analogy is to think about training like planting seeds. The growth doesn't show right away. It's happening underground, quietly and consistently. And when it's ready, it breaks through — often when you least expect it.

The key is to stick with it. Keep showing up to training, keep learning, and the progress *will* come.

82. Adjust How You Measure Progress

When you're stuck in a plateau, it's easy to feel like you're not improving — especially if you're not tapping more people or that next stripe feels like it will never arrive. But that doesn't mean you're not improving. It just means you need to look at your progress differently.

Start noticing the small victories.

Did you escape mount more easily today against the big guy you normally get stuck under? Did you recover guard when you usually wouldn't against an aggressive passer? Did you survive just a little longer against the higher belt who taps you several times every roll?

Those are all real progress.

Not all growth is flashy. Some of it is subtle – showing up when you're tired, staying calm under pressure, trying something outside your comfort zone. It's these tiny wins that eventually add up to real breakthroughs.

83. Go back to the Basics

Plateaus can be frustrating, but they are usually sending you a message. It's your body and brain telling you that a key part of your game needs attention, and it's often something fundamental that's been skipped, rushed, or forgotten.

Even high-level black belts constantly revisit the basics because they are the foundations on which everything else in your game is built. And if you're struggling and stuck in a plateau, going back to them is often where you will find the breakthrough you've been looking for.

Check your posture inside the guard – are you balanced and upright, and dealing with your opponent's grips?

Revisit your base and balance when passing – are you stable inside your opponent's guard, or are you overreaching?

Look at your framing – are you using your frames as a tool to prevent passes, control distance, and recover position?

These aren't beginner concepts – they're the pillars everything else stands on. Going back to them doesn't mean you're going backwards. It just means you are reinforcing the structure that holds your whole game together.

84. Analyse Your Game

Jiu Jitsu is about control. In the perfect Jiu Jitsu game, you make contact with your opponent and progress your position all the way to the submission without them being able to stop you.

Of course, our opponents will always have something to say about that. But you can still use this concept to analyse your own Jiu Jitsu. Do you have reliable ways to progress from every major position – in both Gi and No-Gi – that don't break down under resistance? Do you have a plan B for when things go wrong? And once you reach a dominant position, can you consistently secure and finish submissions?

If the answer to any of those is “not yet,” that's a good thing – you've just found where to focus. *Those gaps are now opportunities.*

Plateaus are a normal part of progress. Sometimes it might even feel like you're going backwards as you work on a weakness. That's not a problem – *it's expected*. Some students even welcome that feeling, because they know an improvement is coming.

85. Narrow Your Focus

If your training feels a bit directionless, try this: set one specific focus for the week. Not a massive goal –just something clear and actionable.

Examples of this include:

- Working on guard retention against a specific guard you've been struggling with
- Trying to hit a new sweep you've been working on at least once per roll.
- Even something simple like trying to calm and survive longer in bad positions.

Whatever you choose, let that intention guide your week. It gives your sessions direction, even when progress feels slow or uncertain.

These small goals build momentum. One week at a time, they stack up – and eventually, all those little improvements will turn into a huge improvement in your level. Don't try to fix everything at once. Just pick one thing and give it your full attention.

86. Did You Improve One Thing Today?

If you're feeling down about your Jiu Jitsu, ask yourself a simple question:

Did I improve just one thing today?

You don't need to level up every part of your game in every session. That's not how real progress works – not in Jiu Jitsu, and not in anything worth learning.

But if you made even one small step forward? That's actually a really good session. And if that's happening, you're probably not doing as badly as you think.

If you can leave class and honestly say, "*I did one thing better than yesterday,*" then you're honestly exactly where you need to be.

87. Take a Round Off and Just Watch

Next time you're at open mat, skip a round – *and watch*.

But not passively, and definitely not while scrolling your phone. Watch *like a coach*.

Look at what setups are working. What movements lead to guard passes? What mistakes are opening people up to sweeps or submissions? Pay attention to reactions, posture, and timing. You'll start to notice patterns – not just in their rolls, but things you recognise in your own game too. And you'll see details that you miss when you're the one in the scramble.

Better still, *coach your friends*. Give feedback. Talk through what you're seeing. It will sharpen your understanding and help them grow too.

A round or two on the sidelines can sometimes teach you more than five rounds on the mat. Observation is training – just in a different form.

88. Ask a Higher Belt to Review Your Game – or Book a Private

When you can't see your own blind spots, *ask someone who can*.

A coach or experienced teammate can often spot small details you've completely missed – lazy grips, poor posture, poorly structured frames or other bad habits you didn't realise you had. Sometimes, one simple piece of external feedback is enough to break through a plateau or unlock a stuck part of your game.

Even a quick chat after class or a few rounds of targeted sparring with a higher belt can shift your perspective.

And if you're ready to go deeper – consider booking a private lesson. Yes, they can be pricey, but the focused attention you get in a one-on-one session can accelerate your progress more than weeks of regular class. The instructor sees your specific sticking points and tailors the session to you.

Here's a tip: if you're a white or early blue belt, consider asking a purple belt for a private. It'll usually cost less, and if they're technically solid and good at explaining concepts, you'll still get a ton out of it.

One outside perspective can save you months of trial and error. Don't be afraid to ask!



Ask a Higher Belt to Review Your Game — or Book a Private

89. Take a Short Break

If you're *really* struggling – not just technically, but mentally – sometimes the best thing you can do is step away from the mats for a few days.

This isn't about quitting. It's about resetting. Don't think of it as a backwards step – think of it as a reboot.

Burnout can make everything feel worse than it really is. When you're tired, flat, and uninspired, even good training can start to feel like a grind.

Take a short break. Let your body recover. Let your mind decompress. Sometimes you just need a little distance to reset — to remember why you love it in the first place. When you come back, chances are you'll feel clearer, more motivated, and ready to train with renewed focus.

Just make sure it's intentional – and temporary. Then get back on the mat and keep going.

90. Maintain Perspective – You're Doing OK

Plateaus mess with your head. They make you question everything – your progress, your potential, even your place on the mat. And the truth is, *these mental roadblocks hit everyone*. They might be the hardest part of Jiu Jitsu.

But take a breath and look back.

Remember your first week? When side control felt like drowning? When you had no idea what guard retention meant? When just surviving a round felt like a win?

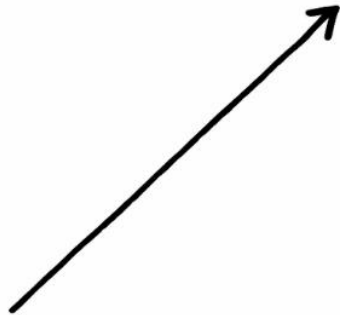
Now look at yourself.

You've built skill, resilience, and discipline. You understand positions, timing, and how to breathe under pressure. You would dominate that old version of yourself if you rolled right now. You might not feel like you're improving – but that's only because your standards have risen with your progress.

Sticking with Jiu Jitsu when it's hard *is* growth. You're still showing up. You're still learning.

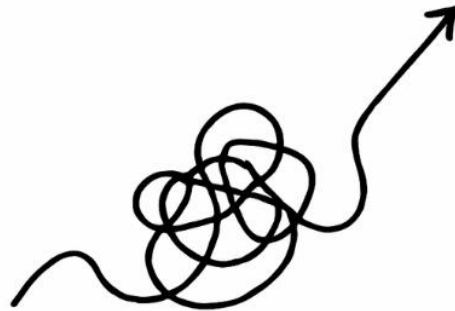
You're doing OK!

SUCCESS



**What people
think it looks like**

SUCCESS



**What it really
looks like**

Chapter 10: Etiquette & Culture

91. Respect the Mat and the Space

The mat is where we train, learn, and grow – keep it clean, safe, and respected.

Always enter clean, barefoot, and in the proper attire. Never walk on the mats in shoes or sandals. Wear flip-flops or slides to the bathroom and changing room. If your gym has customs like bowing before stepping on, follow them.

A clean, respectful space isn't just about hygiene – it shows respect for your teammates and instructors. Be someone who contributes to that.

92. Keep Your Hygiene Game Strong

Hygiene isn't optional – *it's a basic responsibility*.

Shower after class. Wash your Gi and rashguard after every session. Keep your fingernails and toenails short. Use deodorant. Cover any cuts. And if you've got a skin infection – stay home until it's fully healed.

The same goes for colds, flu, and anything else contagious. No one wants to roll with your cough, fever, or viral load. Rest up, recover properly, and come back when you can train at 100%.

You're rolling in close contact with others. Your hygiene affects everyone, not just you. No one wants to train with someone who smells bad, spreads ringworm, or slices people up with overgrown talons.

Be clean. Be aware. Be considerate. Be someone people want to train with – *not avoid*.

93. Be Aware of Your Surroundings

The mat isn't just your space – it's shared by everyone training. When you're rolling, *pay attention*. If you and your partner are about to crash into someone, adjust. And if you're the lower belt, be the one to move. That's just how it works.

Avoid crashing into others, stepping over people drilling, or creating chaos in crowded areas. Injuries often happen not from the roll itself, but from someone landing on an unsuspecting teammate nearby.

Mat awareness is safety, respect, and good training sense all rolled into one. Stay sharp, stay spatially aware, and help keep the mat a safe place for everyone.



Be Aware of Your Surroundings

94. Be Coachable – Especially During Rolling

If your coach offers feedback mid-roll or stops the round to correct something, don't be embarrassed or defensive. Don't make excuses. Just listen and learn.

Being coachable is more valuable than being talented. It shows you're humble, open, and here to learn.

And if a higher belt offers you advice after a round? *Take it as a gift, not a criticism.* They didn't have to say anything – but they saw something in you worth helping.

The fastest learners aren't the flashiest – they're the ones who listen.

95. Encourage, Don't Criticise, Lower Belts

Everyone is on their own journey. We are all progressing at our own pace. We have different bodies, different lives and different struggles. Just because someone's behind you right now doesn't mean they're doing it wrong – it just means they're not where you are yet.

So don't roll your eyes at white belts. Don't critique their every mistake. And definitely don't talk down to people who are still trying to put the pieces together. You don't know what it took for them just to show up today.

If they ask for help, give it. If they look lost, offer support – *not judgment.*

And if they're frustrated, remind them that we've all been there. Be someone that people feel safe learning around – not someone they try to avoid in the next class.

96. Don't Coach During Rolls – Unless They Ask

You're not the instructor – and your training partner didn't sign up for live commentary. Mid-roll coaching almost always comes off as patronising, even if your intentions are good.

Most people are just trying to focus, survive, or work on something specific. So let them. If they want advice, they'll ask after the round – and that's your chance to share it respectfully.

Until then?

Just focus on your own game. Roll and learn. *Don't lecture.*

97. Follow the Flow of the Class

This isn't your personal lab. If the instructor's teaching a technique, drill that technique – not what you watched on YouTube last night. There's a structure for a reason.

Trying out unrelated moves or slipping into coach mode just throws off your partner and disrespects the time and effort your instructor put into planning the class.

Open mat is for experimenting. Class is for *learning*.

Remember that you came to get better – and the instructor has put time and effort into preparing a class that will help you reach that goal. Stay focused, stick with it, and let the instructor do the coaching.



Follow the Flow of the Class

98. Welcome New Students

If you see a new face on the mat or a quiet white belt looking a bit lost, welcome them like it's their first day. *Because it might be.*

It could also be someone coming back after an injury, or somebody walking in with anxiety from a bad experience at another gym. You don't know their story – but you do get to shape their first impression.

Say hi. Help them settle in. Offer to drill with them. Give them a partner when no one else does. These little gestures might feel small to you – but they could mean the world to someone else and be the reason they come back next week.

Good gyms build tough grapplers. But the best gyms build a community and a sense of belonging. *Be part of that.*

99. Support Your Teammates

Jiu Jitsu builds more than just skill – it builds real connections and friendships. The people you roll with every week become more than training partners. They become teammates. Sometimes, they become more like family.

So, show up when it counts.

If someone's competing, be in their corner. If they're injured, check in with them to see how they are getting on. If they're struggling with life outside the gym, take the time to listen.

Celebrate the highs and be there through the lows.



Support Your Teammates

100. Stay Humble in Victory and Respectful in Defeat

Tapping someone doesn't mean you're better than them – it just means you caught them this time. Don't celebrate. Don't boast. Don't make it weird.

And when you get tapped – because you will – accept it with grace. Don't sulk and make excuses.

The mat doesn't care about your ego. Leave it at the door.

Show respect, win or lose – and you'll always walk off better than you were before.

And Finally...

101. Never Forget Why You Started

Jiu Jitsu *will* challenge you. It will humble you, frustrate you, push you past your limits – and it will change your life in ways you never expected.

Along the way, you'll earn belts. You'll pick up injuries. You'll win some, lose plenty, and have days full of self-doubt where you wonder if you're even getting better.

When that happens, stop and ask yourself: *Why did I start?*

Was it for confidence? Fitness? Self-defence? Sanity?

That reason still matters. Reconnect with it. Let it anchor you when motivation dips or progress feels slow.

The path is long. But it's real. It's hard. It's yours.

And it's worth every step. Never forget why you began.



Never Forget Why You Started

See You on the Mats

Putting this guide together has been a real pleasure for both of us. It gave us a chance to reflect on our own Jiu Jitsu journeys – the ups, the downs, the breakthroughs, and the little wins – and to distil what we've learned across more than half a century of combined time on the mats.

Every tip in this book comes from experience. From mistakes made, lessons learned, and moments that stuck with us. If even one of them helps you stay the course, see things differently, or enjoy training a little more – *then it's been worth it*.

Jiu Jitsu is something very special. It challenges us, connects us, and humbles us – and rewards us in ways far beyond technique. Wherever you are in your training, stay curious, stay kind, and stay grateful that you get to be part of this.

Thank you for reading. We hope you found something here that speaks to where you are, and maybe even where you're headed.

If you'd like to connect, we'd love to hear from you, so please feel free to reach out via email or through our social channels at jiujitsubrotherhood.com.

Enjoy the journey. Be grateful for the path. See you on the mats.

– Marc & Leigh

About Marc

Marc Barton is a Brazilian Jiu Jitsu black belt, educator, and former doctor with a background in human physiology and medicine. He holds a BSc in Physiology and an MBBS medical degree, and spent over a decade working on the frontline in emergency and intensive care medicine.

Marc has trained in martial arts since childhood and also holds a black belt in Shotokan Karate. He began Brazilian Jiu Jitsu at the age of 30 and now teaches full-time as the head instructor at [Kingston Jiu Jitsu](#) in London. His coaching blends scientific depth with real-world experience, drawing from both his medical training and years on the mat.

He is particularly focused on helping adults build a sustainable, intelligent Jiu Jitsu practice – one that supports long-term progress, joint health, and technical development well into their 30s, 40s, and beyond.

Marc's approach emphasises biomechanics, skill progression, and thoughtful training habits over brute force. Through his teaching and writing, he aims to make Jiu Jitsu more accessible, effective, and rewarding for anyone willing to show up and do the work.

About Leigh

Leigh Remedios is a Brazilian Jiu Jitsu black belt and lifelong martial artist with black belts in Judo, Traditional Ju Jitsu, and Tae Kwon Do. He is a highly accomplished competitor, having represented internationally across multiple disciplines, including appearances in the UFC, Polaris, and other elite-level events.

Leigh has won several major titles, including the NAGA United Kingdom Grappling Championship belt and multiple IBJJF European No-Gi gold medals.

In addition to his martial arts career, Leigh is a Chartered Principal Engineer with a background in engineering and applied science. He brings a sharp analytical mindset to coaching and has extensive experience preparing high-level athletes for competition, with a focus on technical precision, tactical awareness, and peak performance under pressure.

Leigh now runs a [Jiu Jitsu and MMA academy](#) in Wiltshire, UK, where he continues to coach, compete, and share his deep knowledge of martial arts with the next generation of students.

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